

Big League Pitching Was Mendez' Ambition

By RAMON VILLALOBOS

Alberto (Beto) Mendez' big ambition was to pitch a major league baseball game.

His handicap, he admits, was being comparatively small, physically. He's a little over 5 feet, 6 inches.

But the nearest he got to becoming a big leaguer was one day in the baseball season of 1944 while serving as an interpreter for Andy Cohen's El Paso Texans who at that time were playing in the old Mexican-National League — a Class C circuit.

Andy's Texans were in Saltillo, Coahuila, Mexico, for their final series of a disastrous road trip of northern Mexico. The team was in a 12-game losing streak.

Andy's entire pitching staff had been routed all over the league parks.

This particular day was the team's final game.

"We were gloomily eating in a restaurant. Andy was having trouble in his pitching selection for the game. The pitching staff had been overworked," Beto recalls.

"All of a sudden, Andy, who had gone down the list of his pitchers, gives that managerial look of his and says — Beto, you're it. You pitch today!

Not that he didn't like the excitement of being up there in the pitching mound, but Beto was only the interpreter

for the non-Spanish speaking members of the team. Beto's only pitching experience had been in sand-lot games with local semi-pro teams. Yes, he also had been a bull-pen catcher and bat boy for the popular Mule Washburn Texans of the middle '30s. The club paid him \$90 a month for warming up pitchers before the game and preparing others for relief pitching chores.

Anyway, Beto suited up for the game against his better judgment. He trotted to the mound like Andy told him. Cheers came out of the dugout from the team's lame pitching staff.

Beto will never forget that game.

Here's how he tells it.

"I was pitching in the last of the ninth with two men out, leading 2 to 1, and one man on base. Up comes Ramon Mendoza, Saltillo's second baseman who later became a Texan and a big favorite of El Paso fans.

"He swung and missed at the two curves I gave him," Beto relates.

Overconfident that he had the game wrapped up was his downfall.

"On the next pitch, I threw him a ball. Then, with my fast ball working well, I gave him a chest-high pitch.

"Mendoza swung and connected. It was a high pop to

centerfield, an easy putout. I didn't look back. I figured I had won the game.

"But as I trotted to the dugout," Beto sadly comments, "I heard the screams from the crowd.

"Our center fielder had misjudged the ball!

Mendoza, who was known around the circuit as a speedy merchant, rounded the bases with an inside-the-park home run to give Saltillo the win and shattering Beto's debut as a possible big leaguer.

Of course, there have been other unforgettable events in Beto's 32-year baseball career. Like during the early days of World War II when pitching for a local team — the Pacific Transfer — he struck out Joe Gordon, the powerful New York Yankee slugger in an exhibition game at Camp Luna, N.M., where Gordon was in basic training. In another exhibition game, he tamed Lou Stringer, second baseman for the Chicago White Sox, who was a flying cadet at William's ABF, Ariz. He also treasures his personal association with Floyd Bevins, the former El Paso Texan who almost pitched a no-hit-no-run World Series game.

But the biggest thrill of them all, Beto tells you, is when he obtained his U.S. citizenship in 1957. Born in Santa Eulalia, Chihuahua, Beto immigrated with his parents to El Paso in 1912.

Now celebrating his 61st birthday, Beto, one of El Paso's most colorful baseball figures, is amiably called by his countless number of friends as the "little czar" of baseball in El Paso — the George Trautman of semi-pro baseball.

For these accolades, Beto has plenty of credentials to back him up.

He was president of the El Paso Baseball Circuit Association and personally supervised



MEMORIES — Perennial Beto Mendez, poses with his No. 1 son, Beto Jr., after scoring a pitching victory for Andy Cohen's El Paso Texans of the old Mexican National League. The picture was taken in 1944, as Beto Jr., in a tailor-made uniform celebrated his second birthday.

Three States In Colt Cage Event

SILVER CITY — The Round Valley Elks will travel to the annual Fighting Colt Invitational Basketball Tournament in Silver City, N.M., thus making the two-day, annual cage classic a three-state affair for the first time.

The annual Fighting Colt Invitational Basketball Tournament will be staged at Silver High School, in historic Silver City Jan. 28 - 29.

Round Valley Elks will join two teams from the El Paso, two teams from the Rio Grande Valley in New Mexico

1969. In 1968 the Ysleta Indians won the event.

Tournament Director Lillard Thompson stated the Fighting Colts will enter the annual tournament as favorites this year, but was quick to add any of the seven teams entered could turn the trick and take home the large first place trophy.

The Fighting Colts of Silver, under head mentor Marv Sanders, will feature the tallest team in the tournament with two 6 foot 8 players in the starting lineup. The Fighting Colts will feature Robert Her-

Best Snow Bases Reported In New Mexico Ski Areas

BY THE ASSOCIATED PRESS
Skiers are pouring into New Mexico to take advantage of the Christmas holidays and the best snow bases in the state for more than a decade.

The National Weather Service said a West Coast system might add more snow to the northern ski areas late Christ-

mas and Sandia Peak, also have shared the good snow base. Skiing is also excellent at Sierra Blanca in southeast New Mexico.

Ski areas in New Mexico traditionally do 20 per cent of their season business during the Christmas-New Year's holidays.